

University of Alberta prof loses admin role over views on gender that made students feel 'unsafe'

Kathleen Lowrey received a letter saying her leaving would be in the best interests of the department



University of Alberta associate professor Kathleen Lowrey was dismissed as associate chair of undergraduate studies in the department of anthropology in March. Lowrey says she believes she was dismissed over her critical views of gender. *Supplied*



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EDMONTON — A University of Alberta professor has lost an administrative role in the anthropology department because of complaints that her views on gender were making people feel unsafe.

Kathleen Lowrey, an associate professor of anthropology in the Faculty of Arts, was also serving as the undergraduate programs chair. But, at a series of meetings held during the spring, she says she was pressured to resign from that role for what she believes are her views on gender, and when she refused to do so, she was relieved of the position. She will vacate the chair role on July 1st.

The role, an administrative one, includes duties such as chairing a committee about courses, approving transfer credits and running a special seminar for honours students in the department.

Lowrey says she was told in meetings that complaints, made to the dean of students and the university's Office of Safe Disclosure and Human Rights, were that her views on feminism were making students feel unsafe and there were concerns this was driving students away from choosing anthropology as a major. She doesn't know exactly the nature of the complaints — or who made them — because they were made informally and anonymously, she said.

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She said she was also told she had been discouraging students from organizing Pride events, which she denies. It was this claim which led her to conclude the complaints centred around her views on gender.

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would resign from my position

Following a subsequent meeting with the dean of the faculty, she received a letter saying she couldn't effectively continue in the role and her leaving would be in the best interests of the department. Lowrey said the letter didn't expound upon the reasons for her dismissal, and she maintains she has never been given proper reasons for her dismissal in writing.

The office of the dean of arts or the head of the faculty at the university have not immediately responded to requests from National Post to comment on the situation. However, Hallie Brodie, a university spokesperson, said in an email that Lowrey's "academic appointment ... has not changed," and cited privacy reasons for not commenting on the administrative role.

"We have no further comment," Brodie wrote.

Lowrey boils her views on feminism down to a few key ideas: men cannot get pregnant, lesbians don't have penises and that biological sex is real. She has in the past written for Feminist Current, a feminist blog headed by Meghan Murphy and had a sign on her office door explaining her views.

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who actually took the class

She said her views rarely came up in class, but they did last January when she was teaching a course on the anthropology of women. On the first day, she said she explained her views — with the caveat nobody had to agree with her — and said there would be some readings of texts that aren't in vogue in academia.

“I don't believe that any of the complaints came from students who actually took the class,” she said. “Everyone really enjoyed it.”

Lowrey is a tenured professor, so has certain securities around her teaching and research. “The university has taken the position that if you're not specifically covered by academic freedom, you can be fired,” she said. “I think that's terrifying, I think that's really horrible.”

This is the latest in a series of campus freedom controversies in Canada and the United States, such as the March 2019 cancellation of a speech by lawyer Danielle Robitaille at Wilfrid Laurier University for the Criminology Students Association. Robitaille defended Jian Ghomeshi; the event was cancelled over concerns there would be a disruption of the talk.

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